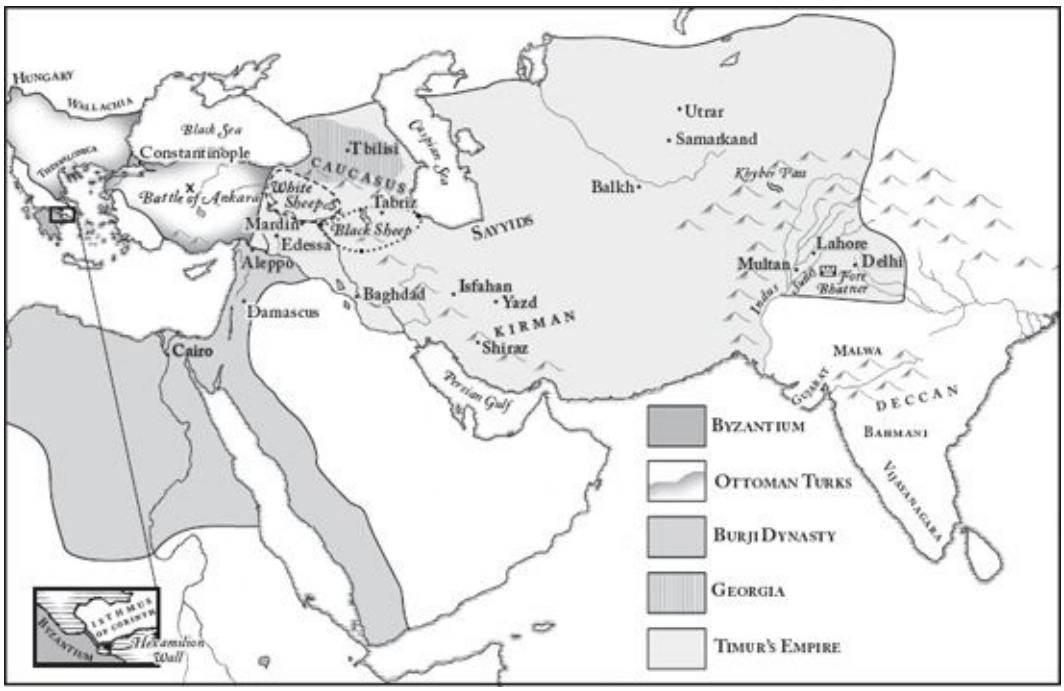
Thessalonica for Byzantium. His next two sons fought furiously over the old Ottoman heartland, a battle that got fiercer when their older brother Musa escaped from Timur's hands and came back home.[9]

Meanwhile, Timur himself finished reducing the kingdom of Georgia to absolute submission. He had for a time agreed to allow George VI, son of George the Brilliant, a small amount of authority in exchange for tribute money. But now he returned, swept across the countryside, and flattened seven hundred villages. All the churches in Tbilisi were leveled into rubble.[10]

The entire Western world held its breath, waiting for Timur to keep on to the west. His goal of re-creating the Mongol empire was not yet clear to onlookers; Manuel himself was convinced that Timur's goal was to first sack Constantinople and then push on into Europe, submerge all Christian countries and kill all Christian monarchs. Instead, the conqueror turned back east, towards China. He had sacked the lands of the Golden Horde and claimed the lands of the Il-khanate. He already controlled the Chagatai Khanate. The old land of the Yuan was the last quarter of the former Mongol empire that still lay out of his reach. He was the reincarnation of the Great Khan; recapturing the Khan's lands was a higher priority than pushing farther into the west than the Khan had ever gone.[11]



89.1. Timur against the Ottomans

He was also nearly seventy. By January of 1405, he had made it as far as Utrar, 250 miles east of Samarkand. Forced to halt by extreme cold and deep